

The Fed shows its working, and the shopper reports three times

The minutes of the July meeting land Wednesday, four big retailers report Tuesday through Thursday, and the first August activity reading arrives Friday morning. **The surprise underneath all of it is which index is actually at its highs, and it is not the technology one.**

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01 The week

Where the week starts, and the two times that matter. **No forecast figure appears anywhere on this page,** and section 05 says why.

7,785.76 S and P 500, Friday	14.25 VIX, lowest of run	4.70% US 10 year	+5.40% Crude oil, last week	2:00pm Fed minutes, Wed	9:45am Flash PMLs, Fri
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Where the scheduled risk sits. Times are eastern. Wednesday afternoon carries the week, and Friday morning brings the first reading that covers August itself.

MON 17 10:00 Builder sentiment, second tier QUIET	TUE 18 8:30 Housing starts, then output 9:15 DATA	WED 19 2:00 Fed minutes, the week's event THE DAY	THU 20 8:30 Claims and the Philadelphia survey PRE BELL	FRI 21 9:45 Flash surveys, first August read ON THE OPEN
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Red top marks the week's main event. Green marks the first August activity reading.

02 Wednesday, and what minutes actually are

One item on this calendar matters more than the rest of it combined.

- Wednesday 2:00 pm, the** (FOMC minutes (the written account of what was argued at a Federal Reserve meeting, published three weeks after it)). These cover the July 28 and 29 meeting. **The decision itself was already announced that day, so the news here is not what they did. It is what they said to each other.**
- Three of twelve officials dissented, and all three wanted a rise.** That is an unusually wide split, and **the minutes are the only place the reasoning behind that dissent gets shown.**

03 The shopper reports three times

Four large retailers report inside three days, and together they are a survey.

- **Home Depot Tuesday. Target and Lowe's Wednesday. Walmart Thursday.** Two sell home improvement and two sell everything, **and those two groups answer different questions.**
- **Home improvement tracks whether people will commit to a big project**, which is sensitive to borrowing costs. **General merchants track whether the weekly shop is holding up.**
- **Friday 9:45 am brings the flash** (PMI (a survey of purchasing managers, scored so that above 50 means growth)). It is the first reading of any kind that covers August itself.

04 Who is actually at the highs

The leadership in this market quietly changed, and the numbers are plain.

- **The Russell 2000, which holds small companies, closed Friday 0.04 percent from its own 52 week high**, having touched that high during the session. **The S and P 500 finished 0.40 percent below its high and the Nasdaq 100 finished 2.33 percent below its own.**
- **So the small company index is nearest its record and the big technology index is furthest from it.** That is the reverse of the arrangement that carried this market up, and **it is the single most useful fact here.**

05 What this page will not claim

Three refusals, each of them deliberate.

- **No forecast figure appears anywhere above.** The calendar source used for the dates **returned finished results for days that have not happened yet**, which cannot be real. **Its dates and times were checked against a second source and kept. Its numbers were thrown away.**
- **Jackson Hole is not this week.** It runs August 27 to 29 and the new chair speaks on the 28th. **Several week ahead headlines name it alongside these five days, which reads like it belongs to them. It does not.**
- **The dealer positioning read is unavailable for the third week running. Blank beats guessed.**

THE ONE LINE

A calm market waits on the argument inside the last Fed meeting and on four shop tills. Meanwhile the small companies, not the technology giants, are the ones sitting at their highs.

SOURCES & NOTE

Sources: Release dates and times: tradingeconomics.com calendar, live lookup August 16 2026 (page renders UTC, converted at eastern equals UTC minus 4, offset proved against ten permanently fixed slots), confirmed against a second independent week ahead calendar; Levels: Yahoo Finance daily bars at the August 14 settle. Earnings dates: Associated Press and Washington Post week ahead, August 15 2026; Jackson Hole dates and the chair's speaking slot: Federal Reserve Bank of Kansas City symposium listing, August 27 to 29 2026.

Educational, not financial advice. A record of what happened and what is scheduled, for Mann's own discretion.

Glossary

FOMC minutes The written account of what was argued at a Federal Reserve meeting, published three weeks later.

Dissent An official voting against the decision. Three did so in July, all wanting a rise.

PMI A survey of purchasing managers. Above 50 means the sector grew, below 50 means it shrank.

Flash An early estimate of a survey, released before the full one. Faster and slightly less complete.

Russell 2000 An index of small American companies. It moves differently from the big technology names.

VIX The market expectation of swing over the next 30 days, priced from options. Low means calm is assumed.

Dealer positioning How options market makers are hedged. It shapes whether moves get damped or amplified.
